

tium of Mumbai Metropolitan Regional Development Authority (MMRDA), Reliance Infrastructure and French company Veolia Transport. "Government organisations resort to only financial analysis, forgetting the social needs of the citizens," says IIT Bombay's S.L. Dhingra, who worked with the Government in drawing up the metro route. The MMRDA says an underground network would cost five times more than an elevated system while Dhingra says it would only double the cost, and in a recent report slammed the Government for not even considering that option.

The construction of the first line, the Versova-Andheri-Ghatkopar stretch at a cost of Rs 2,356 crore, has already tripled travel time from Andheri to the airport and business district. Roads will be scaled back to around 30 per cent and traffic speed will go down by 5 kmph. Footpaths edging the station will be cut back from 8 ft to one-and-a-half ft, posing a hazard for pedestrians. Elevated stations, 150 m long and 24 m wide, will mushroom every kilometre.

The situation is likely to spiral further into chaos with the Government planning to start all nine lines by the end of 2010. "I sympathise with the residents. I am taking their cause for an underground system on the Jogeshwari-Bandra stretch to the Central Government, but it is a tall order," says Mumbai North East MP Gurudas Kamat. Even the state Government acknowledges the practicality of an underground network which will require less land and has the flexibility to expand. But the MMRDA argues that cost is the primary constraint. "If I had a chance I would go underground because the floor is seamless, there's no interruption, there are zero accidents and you can use the space above ground for other purposes. But it's too expensive," says MMRDA's Additional Metropolitan Commissioner SVR Srinivas. But the metro is likely to cost more than currently anticipated; its cost has already jumped from Rs 19,000 crore

five years ago to Rs 35,000 crore.

Although the metro's architects argue that most car users will switch to it, transport expert Ashok Datar says this is unlikely to happen. "People want to spend money on cars, which are a status symbol," says Datar. By 2011, five lakh commuters are expected to use the metro every day, rising to nine lakh per day by 2031.

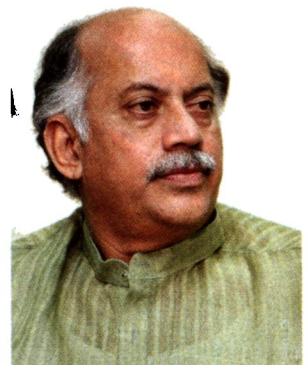
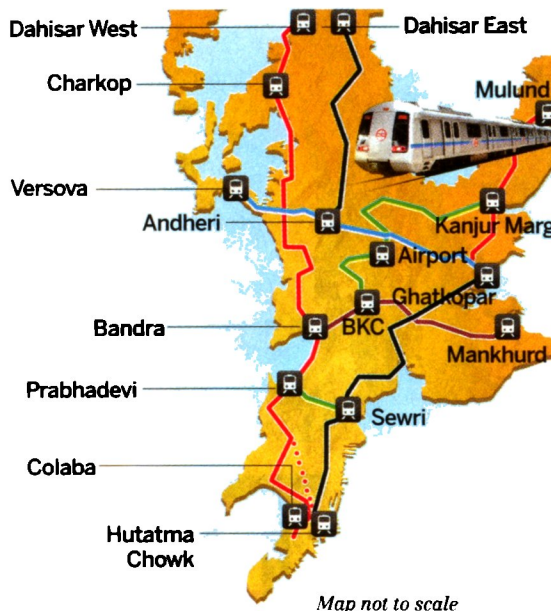
The MMRDA recently pledged to fast-track the entire 146 km project, bringing the completion date forward to 2014 from 2020. To expedite the project, the MMRDA recently set up a

through direct negotiations with land owners and by offering them Transfer of Development Rights (TDR), which convert into lucrative floor space index. But land acquisition will still hit barriers as builders often hijack the process and slumdwellers, businesses and residents exploit the TDR.

This public private partnership venture has come under fire for its financial model. The Central and state governments will contribute only 30 per cent of the funds while the rest will be borne by the implementing company, Reliance Infrastructure for

Construction Nightmare

With the Government planning work on all nine lines, the city will come to a total standstill



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GURUDAS KAMAT, Mumbai MP

single window clearance to push through clearances required by nearly 52 utility owners, which will slash delays by 35 per cent. To dig at any given point, permissions are required from upto 52 authorities, which takes up to three months, while construction takes just 15 days. Delays also stem from the political rivalry between the Shiv Sena-led local authority, the Municipal Corporation of Greater Mumbai which operates most of the utilities, and the Congress-NCP led MMRDA. In addition, the pace of land acquisition will be quickened

the first two lines. But the chairman of the Observer Research Foundation, R. Swaminathan, says that there is no quality control mechanism or checks and balances. "The Government has given a carte blanche to use money in the way they want," Swaminathan says. Srinivas refutes the allegation saying MMRDA monitors the execution of the project while the state Government monitors the broad outcomes. With the city on its knees, what everyone wants to know is: just why didn't the Government build the metro underground? ■